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SECRETS of CAMBRIDGE'S CEMETERIES

Jennifer Bartlau

Cemeteries hold secrets. Walk through an old cemetery, and invariably you will come upon a gravestone that piques your interest, whether it is the symbolic carving wrought by a skillful hand, or the verse chosen by a grieving loved one. Most often, tombstones are simple enough to interpret, but then there are the others.

Vermont author, Joe Citro, wrote in his book *Green Mountain Dark Tales* about "The Mystery of Charles Mudgett." Citro's basic premise is that Mudgett was the "black sheep" of his family, ran away from a domineering father, and was lost to the family for many years. In July of 1890, a train pulled up at the Cambridge Junction station and discharged four armed, masked men, and a very heavy coffin that no one was allowed to open. The coffin was brought to the North Cambridge Cemetery and placed in a vault dug deeper than normal, covered with an enormous piece of concrete, and topped with a giant tombstone. The local rumor mill started churning out that treasure was actually buried in the grave, not Mudgett, and that he was not dead, but was actually one of the masked men accompanying the coffin! What about all the mysterious symbols and sayings carved on the monument? Who was this Milton Everett Milner whose name appears in several places on the grave site, and what was his relationship with Charles Mudgett? Citro's retelling of this hometown tale is colorful indeed. What follows is the "real" story of Charles H. Mudgett's life, death, and return to North Cambridge based on research into records and contemporary newspaper accounts.



Charles Henry Mudgett was born on the 23rd of October 1858, eldest son of Edward Payson and Harriett Chase Mudgett. He appears in the 1860 and 1870 census records with his parents and siblings on the farm in North Cambridge. He apparently left home in May of 1877 at age 18. Later newspaper accounts remember him as a "kind-hearted and social youth." The 1880 census finds him in Yankton, Dakota Territory, boarding with a family and working as an engineer for the railroad. It seems that soon after this census, he headed further West along the Missouri into Montana, where he disappears from all records until June 1890.

On September 11, 1890, the *News and Citizen* of Morrisville reported: "Word has been received here of the death by drowning of Charlie H. Mudgett, son of Hon. E.P. and Harriet Mudgett of North Cambridge, at Fort Benton, Mon., aged 34 years. Mr. Mudgett left this place thirteen years ago last May, and for the past nine years his whereabouts has not been known. At the time of his death he was employed as foreman of the Milner Stock Co. at Fort Benton."

A search of the Montana newspapers reveals that he drowned on June 29, 1890 while herding more than 2,000 cattle across the Missouri River about a half-mile south of Fort Benton. Over the next few weeks, the Montana papers included updates on the manner of death, search, and recovery of Charlie's body. Eyewitnesses stated that his horse lost footing in a rushing current, and he was thrown off. Some speculated that after grabbing the horse's tail to keep his head above water, either the horse kicked Charlie, or he had "taken a cramp or chill" from which he did not recover. Finally, the papers reported that the body had been found "on a bar near Three Islands, some twenty miles below here" on July 19th, and that the "body was brought to the city [Fort Benton] and identified by a ring and a watch. The remains were buried in the cemetery."

Early History of Cambridge

by Ida Morgan Anderson

Beginning in 1935, Ida Morgan Anderson began serializing a column on the History of Cambridge in the *Cambridge Town Crier*. Many of our readers may remember the series of 27 Installments. The Harkener continues publishing the installments for a new audience on the assumption that the copyright (if it ever existed) has long since expired. We hope you will enjoy these "blasts from the past."

Installment Five

Sometime previous to 1826, three men, Mr. Allen, Free Will Baptist, Jonathon Blaisdell and Jonathon Mudgett, Methodists, pledged them selves to meet at the schoolhouse every Sunday evening to pray for a revival until the answer came. Nothing seemed to discourage them or weaken their faith. Sometimes others met with them, but often they were alone. One evening, a stranger came in, took part, and asked to leave an appointment for the next Sunday evening. He proved to be a traveling preacher named Lockwood, returning from an appointment in Jericho to his work in Bakersfield. The next Sunday evening he came with the regular circuit preacher. The house was well filled, and from that evening in October, 1826, dates the revival known as "The Great Reformation", which continued a full year, all denominations uniting.

People came from Westford, Fairfax, Fletcher, Waterville and Bakersfield. Many different ministers helped in these services, some coming from Burlington and even from Canada. The excitement ran very high at times, and some of the people who did not understand the meaning of the shouting and praying were so frightened that they ran out of the house and way out of hearing. Aunt Clara Kinsley who was converted during these meetings, was sixteen at the time and said she "ran because the rest did". She remained a member of the church for over seventy-four years and died when well past ninety.



After the Methodist church was built at Cambridge Boro in 1849 services were still held at the schoolhouse at North Cambridge on Sunday afternoon, the same minister preaching at both places. A family named Wilson lived in that locality. One

of the boys went west and prospered exceedingly. He always retained his interest in his old home and neighbours, and at his death willed them sufficient money to build a small church, with one room for a town library, and \$500 to stock the library with books. The church to be called the "Francis S. Wilson Memorial Church," and to be a union church. It was dedicated January 20, 1904.

The Rev. E.L.M. Barnes was pastor. The sermon was by Rev. O.R. Hunt. The dedication was by the presiding elder, Rev. C.S. Nutter. Other clergymen who took part in these services were Rev. H.A. Sturgess, Rev. A.H. Mohr, Rev. H.C. How-



ard, Mrs. Lillian C. Chase gave a "History of Religious Service at North Cambridge." D.C. Walker spokesman for the trustees, gave an account of the building of the church. H.H. Bessey had charge of the music with Miss Myrtie C. Wallace, organist.

Union church at East Cambridge was built in 1858. Services there were discontinued many years ago, and about 1924 it was made into a community house.



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At the time of Charlie's drowning, his employer, Milton E. Milner was abroad. On August 8, 1890, *The Great Falls Tribune* noted that "Mr. M.E. Milner...arrived from an extended European tour this forenoon...We regret to state that Mr. Milner is...still suffering from nervous prostration which followed the shock the news of the sudden and unfortunate death of the firm's foreman, the late Charles Mudgett, gave him."

Charlie was to have been promoted to Assistant Manager and stockholder of the Milner Live Stock Company in January 1891. Several accounts indicate Charlie and Milton's friendship "was of unusual character" and that "the warmest degree of attachment existed between [them]." *The Burlington Clipper* adds, "For three years they had been associated as employer and employee until the attachment had not only ripened into respect, but a deeper relation."

On November 13th, 1890, the *News and Citizen* announced that Mr. Milner would be bringing Charles' body home for reburial by the end of the year. About the same time, the *St. Albans Messenger* noted that Zina C. Chase had been charged with constructing the vault "with brick and cement to be covered with stone, all perfectly cemented after receiving the casket." One of the rumors about the casket was that it was noticeably heavier than normal. After drowning, not being found for three weeks, buried, then exhumed five months later, the body would have been placed in a lead-lined coffin to prevent odor and leakage during its 2,300 mile journey home. As the train arrived in winter (not summer as Citro relates), bandannas over the face to ward off wind or snow could easily be interpreted as "masked men." From there, the idea of armed bandits is not a far stretch of the imagination.

Milner returned to North Cambridge on September 9th, 1891 to oversee the placement of Charlie's monument and curbing at the grave site. Several local papers reported this event, remarking about the size, oddity, and expense (\$1,000) of such a large ornamental tombstone.

Milner's relations with the Mudgett family did not end with the placement of Charlie's gravestone. Local papers mentioned that he had returned to visit Charlie's mother Harriett in January of 1896. According to Harriett, he visited every 2 or 3 years until his death on June 6, 1913 of liver cancer. He apparently supported Harriett in her widowhood, and left her \$1,000 in his will, along with another \$1,000 for Charlie's brother, William Chauncey Mudgett. It seems another indication of the strength of his connection with Charlie that in his will, after his bequests to his brother, step-mother, and nephew, the very next bequests are to the Mudgett family.

Much of the mystery of Charles Mudgett's grave site and his intimate connection to Milton Milner lies in the monument itself. Set on a slight rise, it is one of the most prominent stones in the cemetery today, and certainly was then. Outside the curbing are two steps, one with "Milner" etched on it, one plain. Standing there, one notices the footstone inscribed with "Charlie" offset on the right, inside the plot. The front upper part of the three-tiered stone reads:



CHARLES H. MUDGETT
Born at Cambridge, Vermont on this homestead
Of his forefathers
Drowned in early manhood, in the
Missouri River, at Fort Benton Montana.
June 29th, 1890,
IN THE EXECUTION OF DUTY.
Brought to the home of his childhood
By his loving friend, Milton Everett Milner.

He was strong, handsome, brave, kind, sincere;
A hero and a gentleman.

Underneath the inscription, on the second tier is the phrase "Ave Atque Vale" (meaning Hail and Farewell), curved over two hearts reclining in a reverse "L." The reverse "L" appears on the left and right sides of the monument as does a strange extended "P." These are cattle brands from the Milner Live Stock Company. Inscribed on the second tier left side is "MILNER," with "MUDGETT" on the right. The back of the top tier has the following verse by the Australian poet Adam Lindsay Gordon:



A little season of love and laughter
Of light and life, and pleasure and pain,
And a horror of outer darkness after,
And dust returneth to dust again.
Then the lesser life shall be as the greater,
And the lover of life shall join the hater,
And the one thing cometh sooner or later,
And no one knoweth the loss or gain.

What is not written, but is possibly key to understanding more of the nature of the two men's affection for each other, is the very next verse, which puts the first in context:

*"Love of my life! We had lights in season –
Hard to part from, harder to keep –
We had strength to labour and souls to reason,
And seed to scatter and fruits to reap.
Though time estranges and fate disperses,
We have had our loves and our loving mercies;
Though the gifts of the light in the end are curses,
Yet bides the gift of the darkness – sleep!"*



It seems obvious that Milner fully intended to be buried with Charlie at North Cambridge when the time came. His name is on the left side of the monument, and there is space to Charlie's left for another vault and casket. But, Milner is not buried there.

Ken Robison, an author and historian in Fort Benton, relates Milner's reaction to Mudgett's death: "The grief of the employer at the loss of such a young man seemed boundless. A silver coin found in the pocket of the dead man was made into a watch charm and worn by Mr. Milner. He supported and cared for Charlie's mother throughout his life as though she were his own and made provision for her in his will, when he could no longer care for her in person. But the most unusual gesture of affection and regret was Mr. Milner's direction that, upon his own death, his body would be cremated, and its ashes strewn upon the waters of the ford where Charlie Mudgett lost his life. That was done."

Left: Milton E. Milner

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Cambridge Historical Society
PO Box 16
Jeffersonville, VT 05464



Because of the Coronavirus and the orders to stay in place, the monthly meetings of the Cambridge Historical Society have been canceled for the last two months. We are currently exploring creative ways to continue to offer our monthly programs virtually, until we can all meet again at the Warner Lodge.

With this issue we start a series by Jennifer Bartlau on stories from the cemeteries of Cambridge. We welcome any contributions you may have on any aspect of Cambridge History.

Stay Safe!

This Newsletter is one of the perks of membership, so to continue receiving The Harkener renew your membership, and THANK YOU.